

LOCAL NEWS JUNE 20, 2008

LIBRARY COLUMN: Automatic e-mails improve library service

George Williams

A little over two years ago, the Latah County Library District joined VALNet - the Valley Automated Library Network. One of the big changes that VALNet brought to LCLD was the Voyager library software system. Switching to Voyager was an essential part of joining the consortium.

I'll be the first to say there are many things about Voyager software I don't like. Voyager has complexities that make many librarians want to throw bricks at their computers and curse, and some LCLD employees yearn for the days when we operated with Unicorn software. But those same employees will be the first to admit that the problems we all experience using Voyager are vastly outweighed by the advantages of having access to the library materials owned by the other 50 or so VALNet libraries.

What makes writing this column refreshing, then, is that instead of complaining about the problems with the Voyager software, I have the opportunity to write about something good that Voyager is now configured to allow us to do - automatic e-mail notifications. This is something that LCLD did not have the option to do with our old software and is a huge benefit of Voyager.

What are automatic e-mail notifications? Essentially just what they sound like. The Voyager system will automatically send Latah County Library District users who have given the library their e-mail address the same information by e-mail that we used to send by postal mail. And more, too. The LCLD has always sent its

users "Overdue" and "Fines/Fees" notices. In addition to these two types of notices, patrons who have given us their e-mail addresses will also now be getting "Courtesy," "Request Cancelled," and "Item Available" notices.

The first of these, the "Courtesy Notice," has the potential to be the most helpful to typical library users. Two or three days before an item is due, the Voyager system will automatically send you a quick e-mail reminder. This could mean the end of late fees for patrons who have and respond to e-mail.

The other two types of notices have to do with requested items. If you have placed a request and it has been cancelled, you'll get a "Request Cancelled" notice the next day. Several things can cause your hold request to be cancelled, but knowing about it allows you to follow up promptly if you are still interested in the material.

The final type of notice, though, is the one that has me the most excited. You'll get an "Item Available" notice when an item you've requested arrives at your library and is ready for pick up. This excites me because I've spent many a day at the Moscow Public Library phoning patrons to say "The book you've requested has come in." It's not that I don't like talking to library users, it's just that phoning 60-80 patrons per day is work that we have always had to try to fit in around all the other work we normally do. The "Item Available" notice has the potential to save the people who work at the LCLD circulation desks an enormous amount of time.

And so do all of the other notices. Between November 1st and April 30th, the library district mailed 2,818 notices to library users via the postal system. And those were only Fines/Fees and Overdue notices. Not only is that a lot of money spent on stamps, but each of those notices has to be printed, and processed by a library employee. Since May 20, when I activated the e-mail notification system, the library has sent 4,208 notices by e-mail. And the whole process of sending e-

mails takes less than 15 minutes per day. The e-mail notification system really frees up those of us working at the circulation desks at the Latah County Library District to spend more time helping people in the library. This translates into faster and better service at the circulation desks and on the phone.

So, if you're interested in getting e-mail notices concerning what's happening on your library account, and in helping the library increase its efficiency, please let us know your e-mail address the next time you're in one of our libraries. And if you don't want to get notices by e-mail, let us know that too. If you don't check your e-mail regularly, then automatic e-mail notifications probably aren't for you.

George Williams is the access services manager for the Latah County Library District.

